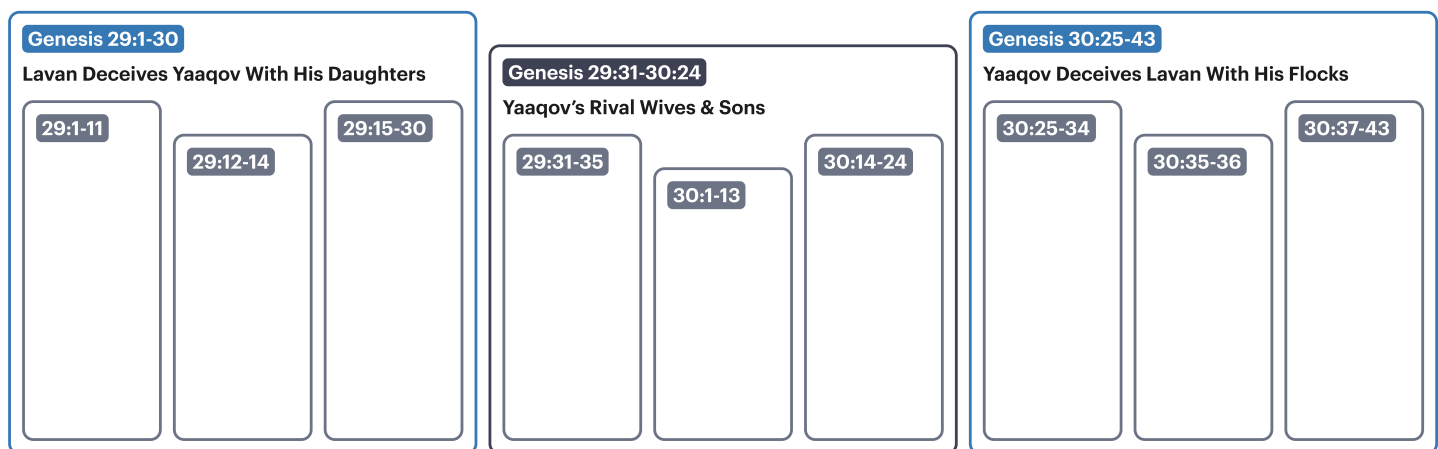


Session 13: Deception in the House of Lavan

Key Takeaways

- Lavan's deception with his daughters is paralleled by his deception with his flocks, providing an implicit critique of the way these men are using women as objects in their power games.
- How we interpret passages depicting the mistreatment of women in the Bible can either illuminate God's Eden ideal for humanity or it can short-circuit the potential of millions of God's image bearers.
- When Yaaqov meets Rakhel, he once again moves forward with his own plan to seize blessing for himself.

Yaaqov's Exile in the House of Lavan



Genesis 29:1-30:43. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

At the very center of the center of the Yaaqov story stands Genesis 29:1-30:43, the narrative of Yaaqov's exile and slavery to his uncle Lavan in Mesopotamia. This large block of narrative has been carefully designed in a nested series of symmetrical patterns. Each paired relationship invites us to meditate on the similarities and differences of the comparison in order to see the deeper message of Yaaqov's exile.

Genesis 29:1-30

Rival Brothers: Yaaqov Is Deceived by Lavan With His Daughters (Named "Lamb" and "Calf")

- **29:1-11** Yaaqov meets secondborn Rakhel (= "Lamb") by a well
 - **29:12-14** Lavan receives Yaaqov into his family
- **29:15-30** Lavan deceives Yaaqov with firstborn Leah (= "Calf")

Genesis 29:31-30:24

Rival Sisters: Rakhel and Leah Struggle

- 29:31-35 Firstborn unloved Leah births four sons
- 30:1-13 Secondborn loved Rakhel schemes to birth two sons
- 30:14-24 Firstborn unloved Leah usurps Rakhel to birth two more sons

Genesis 30:25-43

Rival Brothers: Yaaqov Counter-Deceives Lavan With His Flocks

- 30:25-34 Yaaqov proposes to care for Lavan's flocks
- 30:35-36 Lavan's scheme to deceive Yaaqov again
- 30:37-43 Yaaqov's counter-scheme to deceive Lavan with his flocks

Genesis 29:1-30:43. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Remember, we're already within a larger story about two rival brothers, Yaaqov and Esau, and Yaaqov is on the run into exile because he deceived his older brother. In the Lavan story, this sibling rivalry motif is expanded and explored in multiple ways.

In the outer stories ([Gen. 29:1-30](#) and [Gen. 30:25-43](#)), Lavan and Yaaqov keep deceiving and counter-deceiving each other in ways that strangely mirror what Yaaqov did to his brother and father. Notice also that the first story of deception focuses on Lavan's daughters, who are named after domesticated animals ("Lamb" and "Calf") and then, in the matching third story, Yaaqov counter-deceives Lavan with actual domesticated animals.

In the central story ([Gen. 29:31-30:24](#)), the rivalries of Yaaqov and Esau and of Yaaqov and Lavan are mirrored in the story of the two rival sisters, Rakhel and Leah. They also try to bargain and trick each other to receive a greater share of the blessing of abundance and fertility, just as Yaaqov did to both Esau and Lavan.

In all of these stories, human characters scheme to achieve the Eden-blessing of God's abundance, and they hurt each other in the process. And yet, God meets each of these people, the deceivers and the deceived, exactly where they're at and shows them patience and mercy. However, at the same time, the overarching theme in the Yaaqov story is that God's providence is at work, and even the selfish schemes of Lavan become the vehicle of God's purpose in Yaaqov's life. What Yaaqov did to his family is brought back upon his head, but in order to humble him and make him into the kind of person who can become the vehicle of God's blessing to others.

Yaaqov Meets Rakhel at the Well

- ¹ And Yaaqov lifted up his feet,
and he went to the land of the sons of the East,
² and he saw, and look: a well in the field,
and look: there were three herds of flocks laying down by it,
because from that well they provided water for the herds,

and **the stone** over **the mouth of the well** **was big**,
3 and all the **herds** would **be gathered** there,
and they would **roll away** **the stone** from **the mouth of the well**,
and **they would provide water** for the **flock**,
and they would **return** **the stone** over **the mouth of the well** to **its place**.

Dialogue

4 **And Yaaqov said** to them,
“**My brothers!** Where are y’all from?”

And they said,

“We are from Kharan.”

5 **And he said** to them,

“Do y’all know **Lavan, son of Nakhor?**”

And they said,

“We do know.”

6 **And he said** to them,

“Is there shalom for him?”

And they said,

“Shalom.”

Rachel

And look: Rakhel [= “Lamb”] his daughter was coming with the flock.

7 **And he said,**

Dialogue

“Look, the day **is still big**,
it isn’t time for the **livestock** **to be gathered**,
provide water for the **flock**, and go, graze.”

8 **And they said,**

“We are not able, until all the herds **are gathered**,
then they **roll away** **the stone** from **the mouth of the well**,
and then we **provide water** for the flock.”

Rachel

9 And while he was still speaking with them,

then Rakhel came with the flock that belonged to her father,
because she was a shepherd.

10 And it came about **when Yaaqov saw** **Rakhel**, daughter of **Lavan, brother of his mother**, and the **flock** of **Lavan, brother of his mother**, then he came near, and **he rolled away** **the stone** over **the mouth of the well**, and **he provided water for** the **flock** of **Lavan, brother of his mother**,
 11 and Yaaqov **provided water for** **Rakhel**, **and he lifted up his voice**, and he wept.

Genesis 29:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

An Eden Well in the East

After Yaaqov is exiled from the new Eden of Canaan, he finds himself among the “sons of the east.” This recalls all the “eastward” journeys into exile since the garden of Eden.

Eden	Gen. 2:8 The Lord God planted a garden toward the east , in Eden; and there he placed the man whom he had formed.
Exile From the Garden	Gen. 3:24 So he drove the man out; and at the east of the garden of Eden he stationed the cherubim and the flaming sword which turned every direction to guard the way to the tree of life.
Exile From Eden	Gen. 4:16 Then Cain went out from the presence of the Lord and settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden .
Babylon	Gen. 11:2 It came about as they journeyed east , that they found a plain in the land of Shinar and settled there.
Sodom	Gen. 13:11-12 So Lot chose for himself all the valley of the Jordan, and Lot journeyed east . Thus they separated from each other. Abram settled in the land of Canaan, while Lot settled in the cities of the valley, and moved his tents as far as Sodom.
East of the Jordan	Gen. 25:5-6 Now Abraham gave all that he had to Yitskhaq; but to the sons of his concubines, Abraham gave gifts while he was still living, and sent them away from his son Yitskhaq eastward , to the land of the east.

East of Eden. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

But, just as in “Eden of the east” God provides a life-giving spring (see [Gen. 2:6, 10-14](#)), Yaaqov happens upon a well with a great stone over its mouth. This is an important narrative image that recalls the divine provision of water in the wilderness in the Eden story.

Wives, Brothers and Mothers, Bone and Flesh

Recall how the story about the provision of water in Eden ([Gen. 2:4-17](#)) was compositionally paired with the multiplication of the one human into many through the provision of a wife ([Gen. 2:18-25](#)). This symbolic pairing of “water/wife” from the Eden story has been redeployed already in Genesis in the story of Hagar and Ishmael ([Genesis 16](#) and [21](#)). Here it is drawn upon again.

Yaaqov in Genesis 28-29	The Human in Genesis 2
Gen. 28:10-22 Yaaqov falls asleep alone, and his future multiplied family is revealed to him	Gen. 2:21 The human falls asleep alone and is split into two
Gen. 28:14 Yaaqov is told his future seed will be “like the dust of the land”	Gen. 2:7 The human was made of the “dust of the ground”
Gen. 29:1, 10 God provides a well in the eastern desert, from which Yaaqov “provides water” (שקה) for the flock	Gen. 2:6, 10-14 God provides waters in the wilderness that “provides water” (שקה) to Eden
Gen. 29:10-11 Yaaqov meets his future wife at the well	Gen. 2:23 The man wakes up in Eden (by the river) and sees his new wife
Gen. 29:14 “Truly you are my bone and my flesh!”	Gen. 2:23 “This is bone of my bone, and flesh of my flesh!”
Gen. 29 Yaaqov has left his father and mother and becomes joined to his wife	Gen. 2:24 “For this reason, a man will leave his father and mother and join himself to his wife”
Yaaqov and Genesis 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

The point of the analogy: Just like Yaaqov has been exiled from his home because of the “flood” of Esau’s anger, God graciously provides a new Eden and a new partner for his chosen one as an act of generous mercy. This entire story is set on analogy with God’s appointment of a human after bringing up the dry land from among the waters ([Gen. 1:1-2:3](#)) and then providing a garden home in the wilderness for his chosen representatives to flourish ([Gen. 2:4-25](#)). Yaaqov and Rakhel are depicted as a new Adam and Eve, but we already know from the previous section Yaaqov is not innocent.

The Way We Do Things in Kharan

In [Genesis 29:2-3](#), the narrative focuses on the procedures used by the shepherds for watering the flock and on the timing of watering from the well. The opening scene described the normal day at the well: Herds gather > roll away stone > water animals > return stone to its place.

Yaaqov barges onto the scene, and in [Gen. 29:7](#), he starts telling them how to do their job! “It’s not time to gather in the flocks yet. Provide water for them and send the flocks back out!”

In Genesis 29:8, the shepherds give a curt reply. “We’re not able (לא נוכל) until all the flocks are gathered. That’s when we roll away the stone and water the animals.” It’s a semi-kind way of telling Yaaqov, “That’s not how we do things around here.”

The narrative immediately goes on in Genesis 29:9-11 to show how Yaaqov bulldozes right over their cultural custom. The moment he sees Rakhel, he runs down and does the very thing the shepherds said they don’t do! He rolls away the stone and he waters the flock of Lavan. This entire exchange and the focus on the well seems very purposeful on the narrator’s part.

- When God provided water in the desert for Eden, and when God provided water for Hagar and Ishmael, the water came by surprise and at the last minute, when we thought there was no way forward.
- In this narrative, God has provided a well and a future wife for Yaaqov. But Yaaqov, eager to seize on an opportunity, goes ahead and provides water by himself, on his own timeline, even violating the cultural custom of the east.
- And remember: Yaaqov provides water for Lamb (= Rakhel) and for Lavan’s flock. This is a meaningful portrait of Yaaqov as a brash schemer working from his own agenda regarding Rakhel. This theme will come up again.

The whole emphasis at work in Genesis 29:1-11 may seem random, but it will become very meaningful when we turn to the matching panel of the story in Genesis 29:15-30, where we learn that Yaaqov's brashness was very much noticed by “the men of that place” (Gen. 29:22) and not appreciated at all!

Reflection Question

What are some ways the text signals its critique of the mistreatment of women?